Seranai

OpenFOS

Open Founder Operating System

Value Proposition Design

24 Skills + 2 Reference Modules
Organized by FOUNDRY Framework

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What Is This Skill?

The Value Proposition Design skill helps you build a tight, evidence-backed canvas that maps your product directly to your customer's most urgent jobs, pains, and gains. It answers the question every investor and customer will ask: why would someone choose this over what they already have?

It works as a conversation. You describe your product and your customer, and the skill walks you through building both sides of the Value Proposition Canvas — the Customer Profile (what your customer needs) and the Value Map (what your product delivers) — then calculates a Fit Score that shows exactly where you're strong and where the gaps are.

THE CORE PRINCIPLE

Every pain, gain, and job in your canvas must come from you — or from a source you have reviewed and approved. The skill never assumes.

That's what makes the output worth acting on.

By the end of one conversation (about 20 minutes), you will have a complete Customer Profile, a Value Map showing exactly which pains you relieve and which gains you create, and a scored Fit Analysis that tells you whether your product maps to what your customer actually needs — and what to fix if it doesn't.

Who Is This For?

This skill is designed for founders who have identified their customer and validated their problem — and are now ready to design an offering that maps precisely to what that customer needs. It is especially useful if:

- You've done your problem validation and persona work and want to design an offering that maps to real customer evidence
- You're getting "that's interesting" in sales conversations but not "how do I sign up" — and you want to know why
- You're preparing a pitch and need to articulate your value proposition in terms that map to specific customer pains and gains
- You're choosing between features to build and want a framework that keeps every decision tethered to what customers actually need
- You have a product but your positioning feels generic — it could describe five of your competitors equally well
- You're a first-time founder who hasn't done structured value proposition work before

This skill works for founders anywhere in the world. The canvas is built from the pains and gains of your specific customer — not from US-centric assumptions about what buyers want.

How to Get Started

Using this skill requires three things: access to Claude (claude.ai or the Claude app), the Value Proposition Design skill installed, and a description of your product and customer in your own words.

Step 1: Open Claude and Start a New Conversation

Go to claude.ai or open the Claude app. Start a new conversation. That's it.

Step 2: Describe Your Product and Customer

Tell Claude what your product does and who it's for. If you've already completed Problem Validation (Skill 1) or Persona Definition (Skill 4), the skill will automatically extract those outputs from the conversation — you won't need to re-enter anything. If you haven't done them yet, the skill will run them for you before building the canvas.

Examples of Great Starting Messages:

EXAMPLE 1 — With Prior Work Done

"I've already done my problem validation and persona for this. My customer is a logistics operations manager at mid-size freight companies. Their biggest pain is manual shipment tracking. My product automates this. Let's build the value prop canvas."

EXAMPLE 2 — Starting Fresh

"I'm building an invoice management tool for freelance designers in India. I haven't done persona work yet. Can you help me build my value proposition?"

EXAMPLE 3 — Minimal

"Compliance monitoring software for fintech startups. Help me figure out my value proposition."

All three will work. The more context you provide, the faster you'll reach the canvas. But even a single sentence is enough — the skill will ask only for what's genuinely missing.

Step 3: Follow the Conversation

The skill guides you through four phases. You don't need to prepare anything in advance or remember any steps. Just respond naturally to the questions it asks. The whole process takes about 20 minutes.

What Happens: The Four Phases

The skill walks you through four phases, each building on the last. Here's what to expect at each stage.

PHASE 1: DEPENDENCY CHECK *Ensuring the canvas is grounded in evidence • ~2 minutes*	
What You Do	• Confirm whether you've completed Problem Validation (Skill 1) and Persona Definition (Skill 4) • If both are in the current chat, nothing to do — the skill extracts them automatically • If either is missing, the skill runs it inline before proceeding
What You Get	• Automatic extraction of your validated problem statement, Hair-on-Fire score, and persona card if they exist in the conversation • A single confirmation of what the skill is carrying into the canvas • If dependencies are missing: a fully run Problem Validation and/or Persona Definition before any canvas work begins

WHY THIS MATTERS:

The skill scans the entire conversation history before asking a single question. If your Problem Validation or Persona Definition outputs are already in the chat — even from earlier in a long session — they are extracted automatically. You will never be asked to repeat information you've already provided.

PHASE 2: CUSTOMER PROFILE *The right side of the canvas • ~5 minutes*	
What You Do	• Confirm or provide your customer's top jobs, pains, and gains • If a Persona Card exists from Skill 4, approve what the skill extracts from it • Rank the pains and gains that matter most — not all pains are equal
What You Get	• A structured Customer Profile with jobs (functional, social, emotional), pains ranked by severity, and gains ranked by importance • A most urgent pain and most valued gain — the two signals that the Value Map must address • A sanity check flagging if pains seem too generic, too numerous, or not grounded in customer evidence

PHASE 3: VALUE MAP *The left side of the canvas • ~5 minutes*	
What You Do	• Describe what your product actually does — the core offering and 2–3 key features • Confirm which approach best describes how your product creates value • For each critical pain and desired gain, describe specifically what your product does about it
What You Get	• A structured Value Map with your products and services, explicit pain relievers for each customer pain, and gain creators for each customer gain • Clear identification of gaps — pains with no reliever and gains with no creator • Flags for any features that don't map to a customer job, pain, or gain (candidates for cutting)

PHASE 4: FIT SCORE + FULL CANVAS *Putting both sides together • ~5 minutes to read*	
What You Do	• Review the completed canvas summary • Confirm the Fit Score reflects your honest read of the product-customer alignment • Note the biggest gap to focus on next
What You Get	• A Fit Score (1–10) showing how well your Value Map maps to your Customer Profile • The complete canvas in one clear view — customer profile, value map, fit score, working value proposition statement • A two-week testing sprint plan to validate the canvas with real customers • A bridge to the next step based on your score

Understanding Your Results

The Two Sides of the Canvas — and What Fit Means

Customer Profile	Value Map	Fit
What your customer needs. The right side of the canvas. Maps your customer's jobs (what they're trying to do), pains (what gets in the way), and gains (what they want to achieve). Every element comes from customer evidence, not assumption.	What your product delivers. The left side of the canvas. Describes your products and services, the pain relievers (how you address each pain), and the gain creators (how you produce the outcomes they want). The	When the two sides align. Fit is achieved when your Value Map clearly and specifically addresses the most important jobs, pains, and gains in your Customer Profile. The Fit Score (1–10) measures how well this alignment holds.

	detail here must map directly to the Customer Profile.	

The Five Value Map Approaches

The skill selects the best approach for building your Value Map automatically — but you can always ask to use two approaches in parallel for a richer canvas.

Approach	Best When…	How It Works
Direct Pain Relief	Product removes or reduces a specific pain	Map each feature to a pain it addresses and describe the mechanism
Outcome Delivery	Product delivers a clear, measurable result	Map each outcome to a gain the customer wants — ideally with a number or timeframe
Workflow Replacement	Product replaces a manual process or existing tool	Map what the old way cost the customer vs. what the product saves or eliminates
Risk Reduction	Product reduces uncertainty, compliance risk, or downside	Map the risks your product eliminates to the pains they were causing
Enablement	Product unlocks something the customer couldn't do before	Map new capabilities to desired or unexpected gains the customer couldn't access previously

Reading the Fit Score

After completing both sides of the canvas, the skill scores how well your Value Map maps to your Customer Profile. Here's what each range means:

✅ **8 – 10 • Strong Fit**

Your product clearly maps to what your customer needs. The canvas is ready to inform sales messaging, product priorities, and investor narrative.

⚠️ **6 – 7 • Partial Fit**

The core is right but gaps exist. Identify the 1–2 highest-priority gaps and close them before scaling go-to-market.

⚠️ **4 – 5 • Weak Fit**

Significant misalignment between what you've built and what the customer needs. Revisit product priorities or revisit the Customer Profile.

❌ **Below 4 • No Meaningful Fit**

The canvas needs to be rebuilt on better customer insight. Return to Persona Definition and conduct more customer discovery before proceeding.

The Persona Confidence Flag

The Fit Score is always shown alongside the Persona Confidence Flag — carried forward from Skill 4. This tells you how much to trust the inputs feeding the canvas.

Confidence Level	Source	What It Means for the Canvas
⬛⬛⬛⬛⬛ Research-Validated	10+ customer conversations	Canvas inputs are evidence-backed. Build with confidence.
⬛⬛⬛⬛⬜ Interview-Informed	3–9 customer conversations	Strong hypotheses. Minor validation still useful.
⬛⬛⬛⬜⬜ Evidence-Supported	Market research + 1–2 conversations	Directional. Assumed elements clearly flagged.
⬛⬛⬜⬜⬜ Hypothesis-Stage	Analogies and market signals	Educated guess. All pains/gains marked as assumed.
⬛⬜⬜⬜⬜ Assumption-Based	Founder intuition only	High risk. Run persona validation before acting on this canvas.

Tips for Getting the Most Out of This Skill

Use the customer's language, not yours.

The most common mistake in value proposition work is describing pains and gains in the founder's language rather than the customer's. When you describe a pain, use the words your customer actually uses in conversations — not the polished version you've developed over months. The gap between those two is often where positioning breaks down.

Start with the Customer Profile, not the Value Map.

The natural instinct is to describe your product first. Resist it. Spending more time on the Customer Profile — especially ranking which pains are truly critical vs. merely annoying — changes everything that follows. A product that addresses a critical pain is a painkiller. A product that addresses a tolerable pain is a vitamin. That distinction drives every pricing, positioning, and sales conversation you'll have.

"I don't know" is useful data.

If you don't know which pain your customer ranks as most urgent, say so. The skill will search for industry signals, show you the source, and ask if it matches your customer's reality before using it. Not knowing something tells you exactly what to learn next.

Flag the gaps, don't hide them.

The most valuable output of the canvas is often not the strong fits — it's the explicit gaps. A critical pain with no reliever tells you what to build next. A feature with no corresponding pain or gain tells you what to cut. Founders who take the gap analysis seriously ship better products and write sharper pitches.

Run a separate canvas for each segment you're considering.

If you're choosing between two target customers or two market segments, build a canvas for each. The contrast often reveals which customer has the more urgent pain, the more specific gains, and the weaker current solution — all signals for where you should compete first.

Come back as your customer evidence improves.

The canvas is a living document. As you conduct customer interviews, run sales calls, and learn what resonates, rerun the exercise with updated pains and gains. A canvas that evolves with evidence is a sign of a rigorous founder — and a Fit Score that rises over time is one of the strongest signals of product-market fit.

Frequently Asked Questions

Do I need to have done Problem Validation and Persona Definition first?
Not strictly — but the quality of your canvas depends entirely on the quality of your customer insight. If you haven't validated the problem, your pains may not be real. If you haven't defined the persona, your customer profile is a guess. The skill will run both exercises inline if they haven't been done — it takes about 15 minutes each and makes everything in the canvas sharper.

What if my Problem Validation came back as PIVOT or KILL?
The skill will stop before building the canvas and help you redirect. Building a value proposition on a problem that isn't validated — or one that received a KILL verdict — means designing an offering for a problem nobody has. Address the pivot direction first, validate the revised problem, then return to the canvas.

What's the difference between a pain reliever and a gain creator?
Pain relievers address things that are going wrong for the customer — frustrations, obstacles, risks. Gain creators produce outcomes the customer wants — improvements, achievements, benefits. A single product feature can be both. What matters is that you describe it in terms of the customer's experience, not the feature's mechanics.

My canvas has a lot of features but a low Fit Score. Why?
This is the most common pattern in early-stage products. A low Fit Score with many features usually means the product was built from internal assumptions rather than customer evidence — it has a lot of capabilities, but they don't map to what the customer actually cares about most. The gap analysis in Phase 4 shows exactly which features to prioritise and which to question.

How long does the full conversation take?

About 20 minutes for the full canvas, assuming Problem Validation and Persona Definition are already done. Add 15 minutes per missing upstream skill if they need to be run inline. Faster if you come in with clear customer evidence already articulated.

Is my data private?
Your conversation is between you and Claude. The skill does not store or share your business details with anyone.

Can I use this for B2C ideas?
The skill is optimised for B2B, where the buying dynamics, pricing models, and validation methods are different from B2C. A B2C version is on the roadmap.

I'm in an emerging market. Will this work for me?
Yes. The skill includes specific adjustments for founders building in or for emerging markets, including differences in payment infrastructure, market accessibility, and buying behavior.

The FOUNDRY Framework

FOUNDRY is the sequential journey framework that guides founders from initial idea through scale or exit. Each letter represents a stage, and each stage contains specific skills a founder needs to master.

Stage	Purpose	Skills
F – Foundation	Validate the idea. Confirm the problem is real, the market exists, and you know who to serve.	Skills 1–4
O – Outline	Design the business. Articulate value, map competition, model revenue, scope the MVP.	Skills 5–8
U – User	Acquire and understand customers. Discover needs, design GTM, set pricing, run experiments.	Skills 9–12
N – Nurture	Build relationships and traction. Craft the pitch, model financials, build the founder narrative.	Skills 13–15
D – Discipline	Execute and operate. Set OKRs, hire the team, handle legal and entity setup.	Skills 16–18
R – Results	Measure and iterate. Track KPIs, assess PMF, decide whether to pivot or persevere.	Skills 19–20
Y – Yield	Scale or exit. Confirm scaling readiness, plan liquidity events.	Skills 21–22

Cross-cutting skills (23–24) are not stage-specific and can be invoked at any point in the journey.

Reference modules (R1–R2) are shared evaluation lenses that multiple skills invoke. They are never used in isolation.

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